



Unit 2

Great Thinkers and New Faiths

Learning Objectives

- To learn the causes for the rise of new faiths in the sixth century BC (BCE).
- To have knowledge in the teachings of Mahavira and Buddha.
- To know the similarities and dissimilarities between Jainism and Buddhism.
- To understand the differences between Hinayana and Mahayana Buddhism.
- To know the influence of Jainism and Buddhism in Tamil Nadu.

Intellectual Awakening

The Sixth Century BC (BCE) is regarded as an important period in the history of ancient India. As a land mark period in the intellectual and spiritual development in India, historian Will Durant has rightly called it the “shower of stars”.

Sources

Literary sources

- Angas – Jain texts
- Tripitakas and Jatakas - Buddhist texts

Causes for the Rise of Intellectual Awakening and the Birth of Buddhism and Jainism

There were several reasons for the rise of new intellectual awakening. Some of the exploitative practices that paved way for new faiths include:

- The complex rituals and sacrifices advocated in the later Vedic period
- Expensive sacrificial ceremonies
- Superstitious beliefs and practices that confused the common man.
- Upanishads taught as alternative to sacrificial rites were too philosophical, which a layperson could not understand.
- Slavery, caste system, gender discrimination also contributed to the new awakening.

Origin of Jainism

Jainism is one of the world’s oldest living religions. Jainism grounds itself in 24 Tirthankaras. A ‘Tirthankara’, is the one who revealed religious truth at different times. The first Tirthankara was Rishabha and the last one was Mahavira. Jainism gained